

IN THE NEWS

The Classic Touch

For living legend Bhimsen Joshi, 86, the Bharat Ratna may have come late, but it is not inconsistent with his musical journey or his contribution to the industry. At 11, he went against his father, who wanted him to become an educationist. Instead, he joined a group of bhajan singers passing by his house. The turning point came when he heard Ustad Abdul Karim Khan's thumri, *Piya bin nahin awat chain*. He fell in love with music and left home in the

search of a guru. He travelled in trains sans a ticket and sang for passengers and staff who also indulged him. He reached Gwalior where he began his training in classical singing from Pandit Krishnarao Shankar Pandit. From there, he moved to Jalandhar only to be instructed by Pandit Vinayakrao Patwardhan to pursue his tutelage under Sawai Gandharva, a disciple of Abdul Karim Khan.

His first break came in 1946 when he sang at the Pune Music Circle. After 62 years, he is still regaling audiences with his extraordinary range and emotional flexibility in singing not only khayals but thumris and natyasangeet. His style is predominantly that of Kirana but he has assimilated the best from other idioms, adding depth and variety to his musical presentations. Like most geniuses, his personal life was tumultuous. He started drinking heavily at the peak of his career but quit in 1979 and a new dimension was added to his singing style thereafter. His appearance in the Door-darshan's presentation, *Mile sur mera tumhara*, to promote national integration gave classical music a new life, though its subsequent variations weren't always appreciated by purists, most notably his teaming up with celebrated painter M.F. Husain and his jugalbandi with M. Balamurali Krishna. Yet, he is a man of many interests—singer, actor, football enthusiast and a self-trained automobile engineer. Adventurous by nature, he would often drive from Mumbai to Bangalore or Pune and go straight to perform on stage. For all his flamboyance on stage, his greatest quality is his humility. After hearing of about his Bharat Ratna, he said, "I am extremely happy to accept this on behalf of all the maestros who have contributed to *khayal gayaki* of classical music." **by S. Sahaya Ranjit**



ART EXHIBITION

Revival INSTINCT

In her recent collection of paintings in acrylic, artist Milburn Cherian continues to dabble in her trademark colours. Her palette of amber, ochre and mahogany sustain the medieval theme, with Cherian paying ode to the formative influences of Breugel and other pre-Renaissance painters. Not preferring to create a collection around a theme, in some of her works, Cherian involves Christian imagery which refers to passages from the Bible. While her work acknowledges the influence of medieval painters, she has developed a distinct style. "I didn't go to an art school. So I have developed my own style of painting, where I try to bring back the mood of the 1500s," she explains. At the Art Musings from November 12 to December 7 and then at the Jehangir Art Gallery from December 10 to 16 in Mumbai.

by Swati Mathur

